Bengal, however, was another matter. Ever since Munim Khan's disastrous attempt to relocate the capital and the ensuing plague and devastation, Bengal, isolated from the rest of India for centuries, was viewed with suspicion and fear, a place for renegades, a punishment posting, leading Abu'l Fazl to dolefully record:

> The country of Bengal is a land where owing to the climate's favouring the base, the dust of dissension is always rising, from the wickedness of men families have decayed, and dominions (have been) ruined. Hence in old writings, it was called Bulghakkhana (house of turbulence).

Everything in Bengal appeared foreign and provocative to the Mughals stationed there, from the diet of rice and fish to those used to wheat and meat, to the deluge and foetid heat of the tropical thunderstorms, to the main occupation of the locals, fishing, deemed unworthy by the warrior mansabdars. Something of even Abu'l Fazl's puzzlement can be understood through his bizarre description of the region when he writes that the 'inhabitants are as a race good-looking and addicted to the practice of magic. Strange stories are told regarding them. It is said that they build houses, of which the pillars, walls and roofs are made of men…. There grows a wonderful tree whose branches when cut, exude a sweet liquid which quenches the drought of those athirst.' A land of sorcery and danger, then, but extraordinarily fecund, for Abu'l Fazl also wrote that 'harvests are always abundant, measurement is not insisted upon, and revenue demands are determined by establishment of the crop. His Majesty,' continues Abu'l Fazl, 'in his goodness has confirmed this custom,' reflecting the ground reality wherein Mughal occupation at this time remained nominal.

While almost all the zamindars in Bengal were Kayasthas, as the province increasingly integrated into the Mughal Empire, the Mughal governors would bring in a host of immigrants from other parts of the country to help them settle the land:

> soldiers recruited from the north, Marwari merchants who accompanied and helped finance their Mughal patrons, swarms of petty clerks attached to Mughal officers, and the many artisans who supplied and equipped the Mughal military establishment.